

MARKETING & SALES FOR SMBS

The 6 *leaks.*

The six operational leaks I see over and over in the marketing and sales of small and mid-sized businesses, how to measure them, and the decision each one calls for.

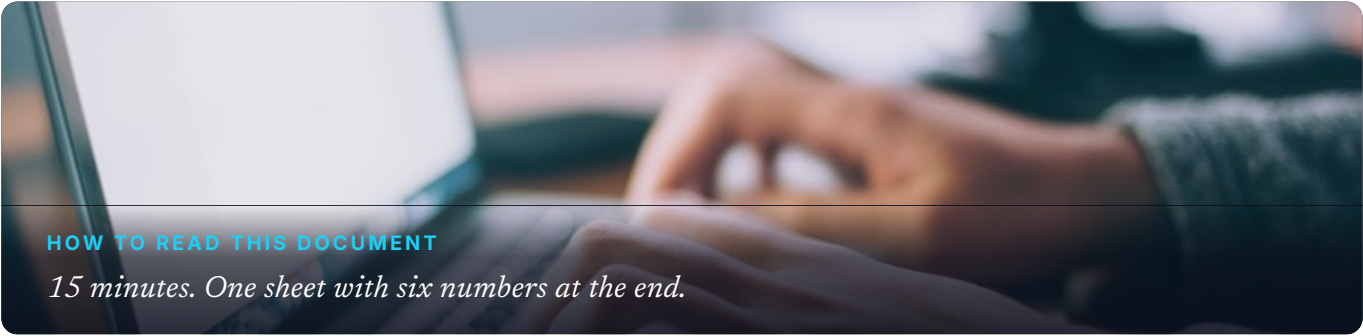
A 15-minute read · 5 days to fix the first one



Jose María Moscardó

Founder, MosLab

moslab.org



HOW TO READ THIS DOCUMENT

15 minutes. One sheet with six numbers at the end.

INTRODUCTION

What this document *is for*

This is not a guide. It is an audit. By the time you finish reading it (15 minutes) you will have a sheet with six numbers that tell you, in euros, where money is walking out of your marketing and sales every month.

Who it is for: marketing and sales teams in companies of 5 to 50 people that already have traction (you sell, leads come in, you have customers) but suspect you are leaving money on the table because of manual processes. It does not apply if you are still validating your product.

WHAT YOU GET

- A framework to tell apart the six most common operational leaks in an SMB.
- For each leak: how to measure it with data you already have, the threshold where it should worry you, a cost estimate, and the first decision to make.
- A scoring table to prioritise.
- A five-day plan to fix the worst one.

What you will not get: step-by-step tutorials, tool comparisons, or funnel theory.

FRAMEWORK

What a "leak" is

A leak is a point in your sales or marketing process where you are losing money through inaction, not incompetence. Three traits:

1. **It is invisible on the P&L.** It never shows up as a cost — it shows up as revenue that never arrives.
2. **It scales with volume.** The more you grow, the more it bleeds.
3. **It has a threshold.** Below a certain volume it is not worth fixing; above it, building a system pays for itself.

The six leaks below show up systematically in companies between 5 and 50 employees, in sectors like professional services, real estate, education, healthcare and e-commerce. They are not ordered by severity — they follow the customer journey.

LEAK 5 · CONTENT — CUTS ACROSS THE WHOLE FUNNEL



LEAK 6 · DATA & REPORTING — CUTS ACROSS EVERYTHING

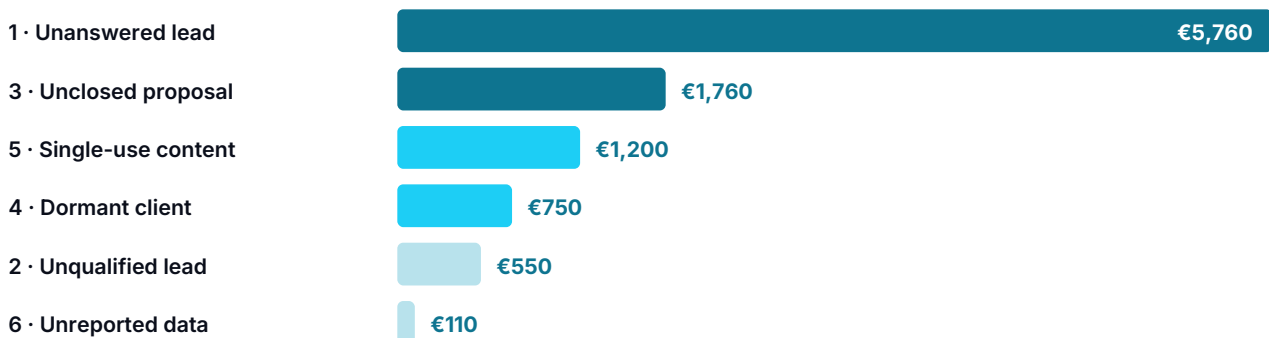
The 4 leaks along the sales journey, plus the 2 cross-cutting ones that amplify them.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A payroll advisory firm

Before we get to the six leaks, a concrete example. A B2B payroll and labour advisory firm in Málaga: 12 people, 80 leads/month (organic + LinkedIn Ads), average annual ticket of €1,800, current close rate 18%. Current new-business revenue: ~€25,900/month.

A quick audit, done in one morning, looking at CRM data and the sales rep's calendar:



Estimated total

€10,130 / month

Leaks 1 + 3 concentrate 74% of the monthly cost: that is your Pareto.

Two things matter here. First: the owner had gone 18 months without touching any of this, estimating he was "losing a bit of money". Ten thousand a month is €120K a year — a full-time salesperson. Second: two leaks concentrate three quarters of the cost. That Pareto tail is what the rest of this document helps you find in your own business.

LEAK 1 · UNANSWERED LEAD

Minute 5 makes the difference. After that, everything costs more.

LEAK 1

The *unanswered* lead

SYMPTOM

Forms, calls, WhatsApp messages or portal leads (property portals, healthcare directories, Google Ads...) come in, and the first reply takes hours, days, or never happens. The dangerous variant: you reply fast during office hours and not at all outside them.

HOW TO MEASURE IT WITH DATA YOU ALREADY HAVE

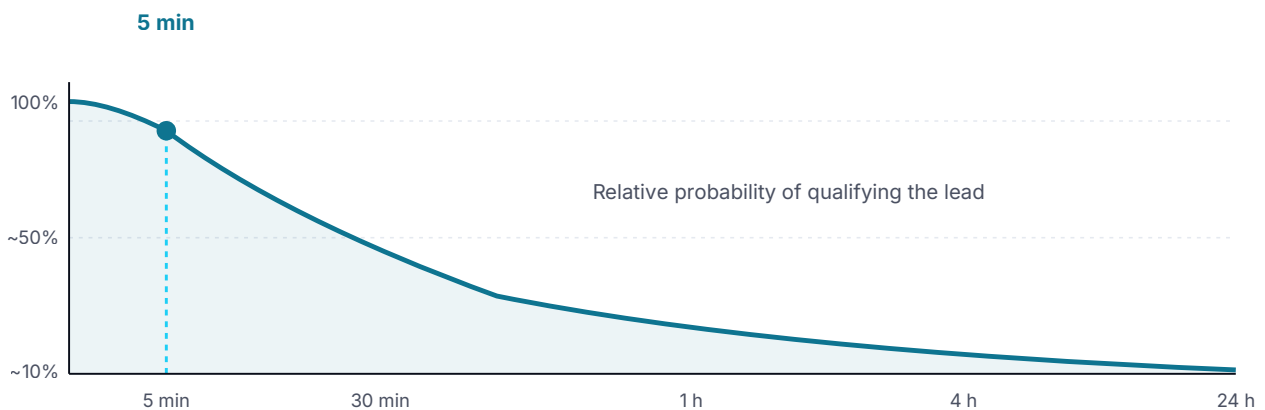
- Take your last 30 leads. For each one, work out the time between the lead arriving and the first useful message sent by a human (not an auto-reply).
- Compute the **median**, not the average. One instant reply followed by three replies three days later distorts the average.
- If your CRM does not log it, export the rep's inbox and your lead sheet and cross them. One hour of work.

THRESHOLD

If the median is over 30 minutes during business hours, or more than 15% of leads wait over 4 hours for a reply, you have a leak.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

Consistent research since 2007 (MIT Lead Response, Harvard Business Review) shows the probability of qualifying a lead drops roughly 80% between minute 5 and minute 30. In B2B services, replying within 5 minutes versus over an hour roughly doubles the close rate.



After minute 5, every hour that passes costs you clients. The curve is not linear — it is exponential.

Napkin math: if you get 100 leads/month, your close rate is 8% and your average ticket €3,000, moving from a 4-hour median reply to under 30 minutes can push the rate to 12%. That is 4 extra sales a month = **an additional €12,000/month**.

THE DECISION IT CALLS FOR

- Do I qualify before handing over to a human? (conversational qualifier → sales rep).
- WhatsApp as first response, or email only? Depends on the acquisition channel: property portals and Google Ads → WhatsApp wins easily.
- What happens outside office hours? Acknowledgement + automatic scheduling + morning handoff.

THE MINIMUM THE SYSTEM MUST DO

- Auto-acknowledgement in under 30 seconds on the channel the lead came in on.
- Basic qualification (budget, timing, fit) by bot or form before a rep gets involved.
- Assignment to the rep with the lead's full context, not just an email address.
- Automatic retry at T+15min, T+1h and T+24h if the lead does not reply.

Marta López
online

Hi, I saw your listing on the portal. Is it still 22:43

Hi Marta! We got your message. We can call you tomorrow at 9:00 — OK? 22:43

⚡ AUTO · 18 SEC

Yes, works for me. I wanted to ask if pets are allowed 22:44

THE SYSTEM BEHIND THAT MESSAGE

3 pieces: detector, qualifier, scheduler.

1. A webhook receives the portal lead and triggers the flow.
2. Acknowledgement + qualification on timing and fit.
3. Assignment to the rep with the lead's full context.

Before
4 h
median reply

After
<1 min
automatic 24/7

Impact
+50%
close rate

What the lead sees on WhatsApp and what happens behind it. A three-piece system, with no rep involved.

LEAK 2

The *unqualified* lead

SYMPTOM

Your sales rep spends time on calls with people who will never buy (they do not decide, have no budget, have no date). The pipeline is full of "still interested" with no movement.

HOW TO MEASURE IT

- From your last 50 closed opportunities: how many would have been discarded on the first call with three questions (budget, decision-maker, urgency)?
- If your CRM tracks lead → SQL → opportunity → client, look at SQL→opportunity conversion. Below 40% is suspicious.

THRESHOLD

If more than 30% of sales calls end in neither a proposal nor a clean discard, you have a qualification problem, not a product problem.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

A rep on €35,000/year costs about €22/hour fully loaded. A qualification call that should take 10 minutes and takes 45 is €12 thrown away. Multiply by 50 calls a month and that is **€600/month** in wasted sales hours — before counting the opportunity cost of not selling to good leads.

THE DECISION IT CALLS FOR

- Who qualifies? (form, bot, SDR, rep). Depends on your cost per lead.
- Which three questions are non-negotiable before a lead reaches sales? They vary by sector, but there are rarely more than three.
- What happens to the lead that does not qualify? Do not throw it away: automated nurturing.

THE MINIMUM THE SYSTEM MUST DO

- A 3-5 question qualification step in the form or the bot.
- Simple scoring logic (points per answer) that separates "rep calls now" from "email nurturing".
- A separate queue for unqualified leads that receives 4-6 value emails over three months, with a trigger back to sales if they click on something specific.

WHAT THIS LEAK LOOKS LIKE BY SECTOR

Real estate: viewings booked for properties outside the buyer's budget. **Aesthetic clinics:** consultations for treatments with no available budget that eat up practitioners' time. **B2B:** meetings with people who do not decide and are "just gathering information". **Education:** enrolments requested by third parties with no ability to pay.

LEAK 3

The *unclosed* proposal

SYMPTOM

You send quotes and they vanish into limbo. Nobody follows up. The owner is busy with clients. The prospect disappears.

HOW TO MEASURE IT

- Of your last 30 proposals sent (more than 30 days ago), how many sit in "no reply"? Over 25% — acute leak.
- Average time between sending a proposal and closing it (yes or no). Over 21 days with no touchpoint in between — chronic leak.

THRESHOLD

Any proposal without a scheduled touchpoint within seven days of sending is at risk.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

If you send 20 proposals a month at an average ticket of €2,000 and close 25% (= €10,000/month), a well-built 14-day follow-up sequence easily moves the close rate to 33%. That is an extra €3,200/month = **€38,400/year from fixing a single leak**.

THE DECISION IT CALLS FOR

- Does a human send the follow-up, or do I automate it? If your ticket is over €5,000, mix both: low-cost automated emails + 1-2 human touches at key moments.
- What cadence? Template below.
- What do I do with "I'm still thinking about it"? It is a deferred no. Treat it as long nurturing, not active pipeline.

A 14-DAY BASE CADENCE THAT WORKS IN B2B SERVICES



DAY	CHANNEL	MESSAGE
0	Email	Proposal sent + three-line summary + a proposed date to resolve questions.
+2	WhatsApp / Email	"I saw you opened the proposal. Anything that fits — or anything that grates? 5 minutes beats a long email."
+5	Email	A use case similar to theirs (one paragraph) + a concrete result figure.
+9	Call / WhatsApp	"Bad timing, or is something not fitting? Tell me and we will figure it out."
+12	Email	"One last thing: if after these two weeks you do not see a fit, the most useful thing is to tell me. I will stop bothering you and keep the quote valid for 30 more days."
+14	CRM	Stage change to "cold lead with valid quote". Enters automatic quarterly nurturing.

WHAT THIS LEAD LOOKS LIKE BY SECTOR

Accounting & advisory firms: quotes sent mid tax season that the client "will look at in January". **Agencies & consultancies:** proposals stuck in "thinking about it" for months. **B2B:** quotes sent before the summer break that nobody picks up in September. **Education:** enrolments needing family sign-off that stall halfway.

Inbox · Drafts · Templates

DAY +5

TO marta.lopez@advisory-firm.com

FROM jose@moslab.org

How a firm like yours went from 10 to 14 closed proposals a month

Marta,

Three months ago an advisory firm much like yours (12 people, legal sector) reorganised its lead response and proposal follow-up. In 90 days they went from closing 10 to 14 proposals a month — without hiring anyone. Here is the case in case it is useful.

15-minute virtual coffee this week? My calendar: moslabs.zohobookings.eu

Jose

Day +5 of the cadence: a real case from a nearby sector + a concrete number + a low-commitment invitation.



LEAK 4 · DORMANT CLIENT

Winning a client back costs 7 times less than winning a new one.

LEAK 4

The *dormant* client

SYMPTOM

You have clients who bought once, were happy, and were never heard from again. Your "former clients" or "inactive clients" list outweighs your pipeline of new leads — and nobody works it.

HOW TO MEASURE IT

- Ratio of "revenue from repeat clients / total revenue". In professional services it usually sits at 30-50%; it should be higher.
- Count clients who bought more than 12 months ago and never came back. What share of your base is that?

THRESHOLD

If more than 40% of your clients bought once and have not returned in 12 months, you do not have an acquisition problem: you have a post-sale relationship problem.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

A recovered client costs 3 to 7 times less than a new one (HBR, several sector studies). If your sector's typical acquisition cost is around €300, recovering 5 inactive clients a month saves you about **€1,500/month in CAC** and adds recurring revenue.

THE DECISION IT CALLS FOR

- Who triggers the reactivation? A fixed calendar for the rep vs. an automatic trigger, depending on the sector.
- What excuse do you have to reach out again without being a pest? A relevant update, a regulatory change, a free audit of their case.
- Do you reactivate by email, by phone, or both?

THE MINIMUM THE SYSTEM MUST DO

- Automatic reminder to the rep X months after the last contact, with the client's context (what they bought, when, what they said) to personalise the touch.
- Automatic "relevant news" email when something changes in your sector or service that affects them (advisory firm: tax change; clinic: new technique; etc.).
- A review or survey system at 3 and 12 months to keep the relationship alive.

WHAT THIS LEAK LOOKS LIKE BY SECTOR

Dental clinics: patients with no check-up in 12+ months (almost always half your base). **Advisory firms:** former clients who left and would be recoverable with one touch after a regulatory change. **E-commerce:** customers with a single historic purchase and never a second. **Real estate:** buyers closed 3-5 years ago who are due a move.

**Marina Ruiz**

m.ruiz@northside-realty.com · Northside Realty

RECOVERABLE

11 MONTHS NO CONTACT

Last purchase

Feb 2025 · €1,800 / yr

Trigger

Tax rule change 2026

Trigger reactivation →

Inactive > 12 months

287

out of 612 clients in total

Recoverable (high prob.)

42

~5 a month with a sequence

CRM view: inactive client with a relevant trigger (regulatory change) → automatic reactivation sequence.

LEAK 5

Content *used only once*

SYMPTOM

Someone spends hours on a LinkedIn post, a blog article, a video or a whitepaper — and it lives on one channel only. If it is on the blog, it never reaches Instagram. If it is on Instagram, it never becomes an email. If it is a video, it never gets transcribed into an article.

HOW TO MEASURE IT

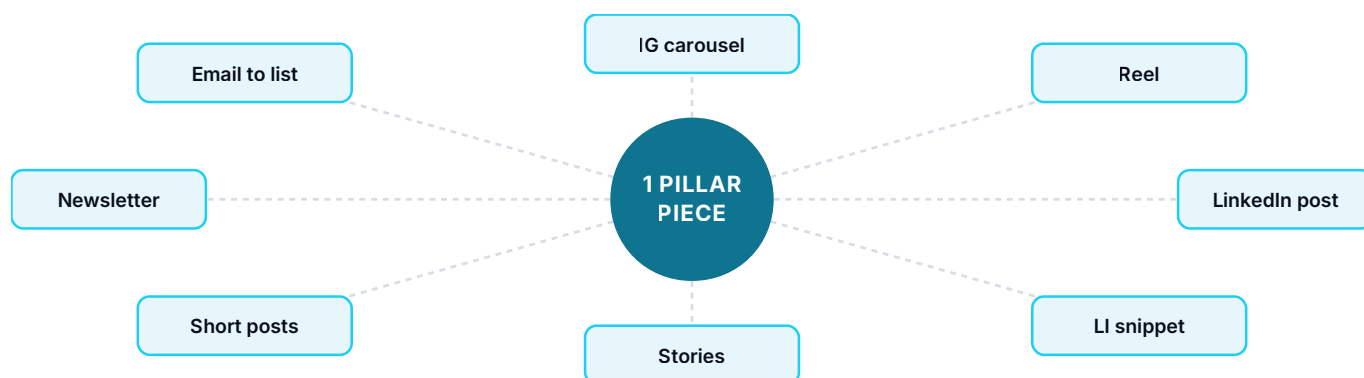
- Take your last 10 pieces of content. How many live on more than one channel? How many were emailed to your list?
- Estimate the production cost per piece (in-house hours or agency).

THRESHOLD

If less than 30% of your content is reused on at least one other channel, you are duplicating production cost to multiply your reach by one.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

A well-produced pillar piece (a 1,200-word article or a 5-minute video) costs €200-400 in time and design. From it — with no extra effort — you can get an email to your list, 2-3 carousels, 4 short posts, 1 reel and a couple of LinkedIn snippets. If you produce 4 pillar pieces a month and reuse them, **you multiply your output by 8 without touching production cost.**



The 1 → 8 system: one master piece feeds eight channels with no extra production.

THE DECISION IT CALLS FOR

- Do I produce less and reuse more, or produce a lot and waste it? The first path almost always wins.
- Does a human do the adaptation, or AI with review? For SMBs, AI with templates and a final human review is the sensible option.
- Which channel is the master? One, not three.

THE MINIMUM THE SYSTEM MUST DO

- One master channel per piece (usually long-form blog or video).
- An automated workflow that, on publishing to the master, drafts versions for the other channels (carousel, email, LinkedIn post) for a human to review before publishing.
- One single calendar, not one per channel.

WHAT THIS LEAK LOOKS LIKE BY SECTOR

Clinics: a before/after treatment video that stays on Instagram and never reaches the blog or Google. **Advisory firms:** a tax-update LinkedIn post that deserves a long blog article + an email to the client base + a reminder. **Real estate:** a property video that lives only on the portal and never on your own channels. **Education:** a recorded class that never gets transcribed or cut up for acquisition.

LEAK 6

Data *nobody* reports

SYMPTOM

On the last day of the month, someone spends 3-6 hours copying data from five tools (CRM, Google Analytics, Meta Ads, email platform, social platform) and pasting it into a spreadsheet for the report. The owner reads it and nothing changes.

HOW TO MEASURE IT

- Monthly hours spent on reporting. If it is centralised in one person, just ask them.
- How many decisions were made in the last 6 months thanks to a number in the report? If fewer than 2, the report is decoration.

THRESHOLD

If you spend more than 2 hours a month collecting data and less than 30 minutes discussing it, your pipeline is upside down.

WHAT IT COSTS YOU

4 hours/month at €22/h = €88/month in production. The bigger cost: the opportunity cost of not deciding with data. An SMB that reports late decides late.

THE DECISION IT CALLS FOR

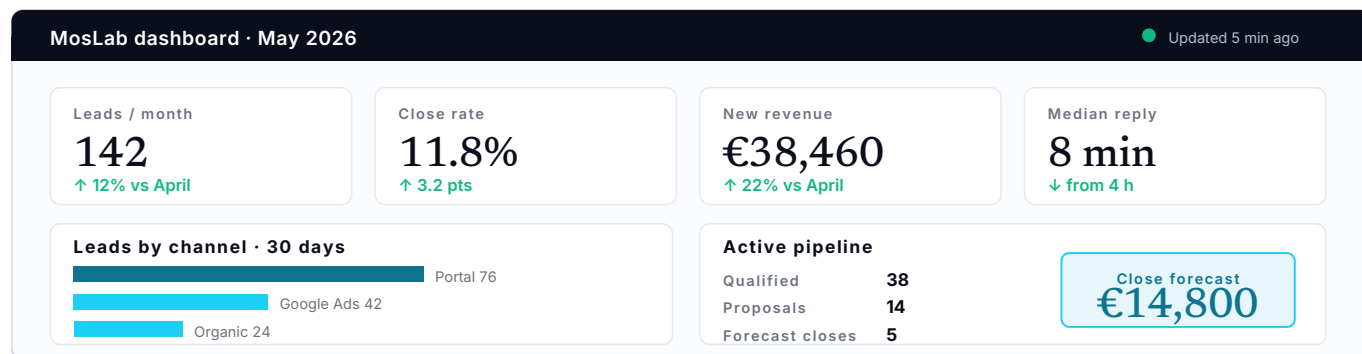
- Which 5-7 metrics are non-negotiable, and why? If you cannot answer the "why" of each one, it is surplus.
- Who looks at them, and what for? A report without a review meeting is dead paper.
- Daily, weekly, monthly? Different answers for operational marketing vs. management.

THE MINIMUM THE SYSTEM MUST DO

- One single dashboard (Looker Studio, Notion, Airtable, Sheets with connectors) that refreshes itself.
- A short list of metrics: leads/month, cost per lead, response rate, open opportunities, close rate, revenue, repeat rate. Full stop.
- A fixed 30-minute monthly meeting to look at it. No meeting — no dashboard needed.

WHAT THIS LEAK LOOKS LIKE BY SECTOR

Real estate: portal leads and organic leads mixed together with no idea which converts better. **B2B:** average sales cycle untracked, decisions by gut feel. **E-commerce:** ROAS per channel crossed with organic traffic — no idea which campaign deserves more budget. **Clinics:** calendar occupancy and patient source disconnected.



One screen, seven numbers, an informed decision. Useful reporting fits in a dashboard that updates itself.

The *scoring* table

Two steps. First, score your situation from 0 to 3 on each leak:

- **0:** this leak does not apply to my business.
- **1:** already solved (system running and monitored).
- **2:** I suspect it but have not measured it.
- **3:** I have it, I can see it, and I have done nothing.

Second, estimate the cost with the matching formula. **Do not eyeball it:** use real numbers (yours, pulled from the CRM or your spreadsheet).

MONTHLY COST FORMULAS

LEAK	FORMULA	EXAMPLE
1 · Unanswered lead	leads/mo × ticket × Δ close rate	100 × €3,000 × 4% = €12,000/mo
2 · Unqualified lead	bad calls/mo × hrs lost × €22	50 × 0.5 × 22 = €550/mo
3 · Unclosed proposal	proposals/mo × ticket × Δ close rate	20 × €2,000 × 8% = €3,200/mo
4 · Dormant client	recoverable clients/mo × repeat ticket	5 × €1,500 = €7,500/mo
5 · Single-use content	pillar pieces × prod cost × (channels - 1)	4 × €300 × 4 = €4,800/mo
6 · Unreported data	hours/mo × €22/h	5 × 22 = €110/mo (minimum)

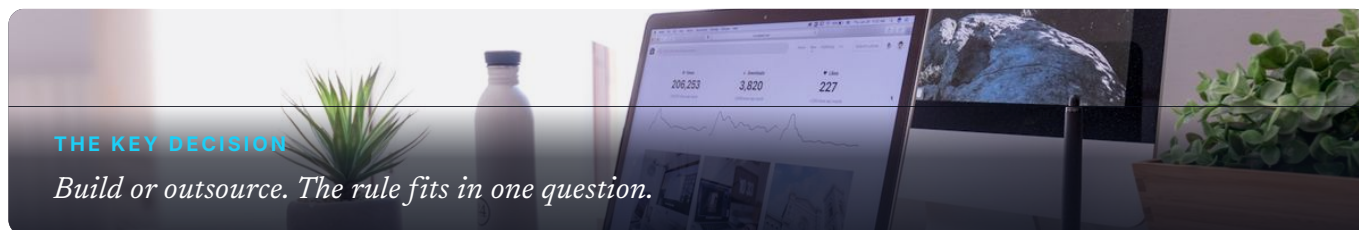
Notes. Δ close rate is how much you estimate fixing the leak will improve your close rate (3-5 points on leak 1, 5-10 points on leak 3). On leak 5 you are measuring the equivalent value of the reach you are giving away, not direct savings: halve it for a conservative estimate. €22/h is the approximate fully-loaded cost of a junior hire in Spain on a €35K salary; adjust to your reality.

YOUR TABLE

LEAK	MY SCORE (0-3)	ESTIMATED COST / MONTH
1 · Unanswered lead	—	€ —
2 · Unqualified lead	—	€ —
3 · Unclosed proposal	—	€ —
4 · Dormant client	—	€ —
5 · Single-use content	—	€ —
6 · Unreported data	—	€ —

LEAK	MY SCORE (0-3)	ESTIMATED COST / MONTH
Estimated total		€ __ / month

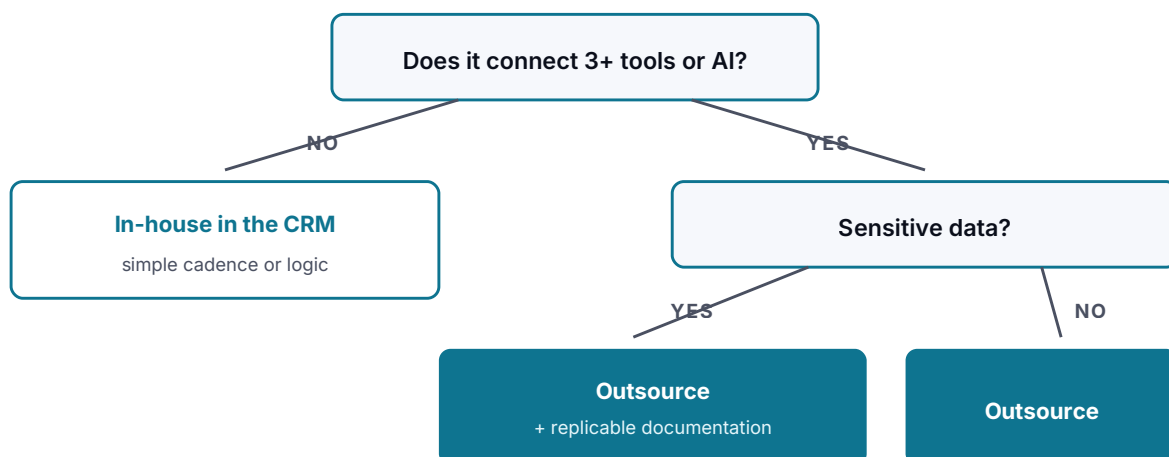
Rule of thumb: fix the leak with the highest estimated cost/month that scores 2 or 3. Not the easiest one. The most expensive one.



THE KEY DECISION

Build *vs.* outsource

Most SMBs try to fix these leaks with the in-house team and stall halfway. Not for lack of ability — building the technical flow is simply not their main job.



A quick decision when you are unsure whether to fix the leak in-house or outside.

What *not* to automate

This matters as much as the six leaks. Automating the wrong spot turns a slow process into a fast broken one. What should not be automated in an SMB:

✗ Processes you do not yet understand manually

If you cannot describe the process step by step on one sheet of paper, do not automate it. Automating chaos amplifies chaos. First order it on paper, then add tools. The single most common cause of failed automation projects.

✗ The first sales meeting on high tickets

If your ticket is >€5,000, the first meeting is a human looking into the camera. What gets automated is everything around it: scheduling, reminders, the rep's briefing, the follow-up afterwards. Not the meeting.

✗ Replies to complaints and serious problems

An auto-reply to an angry customer makes them angrier. These cases go straight to a human with high priority, and the loop is closed by hand. What you do automate: detecting the alert keywords and pinging the right human in under a minute.

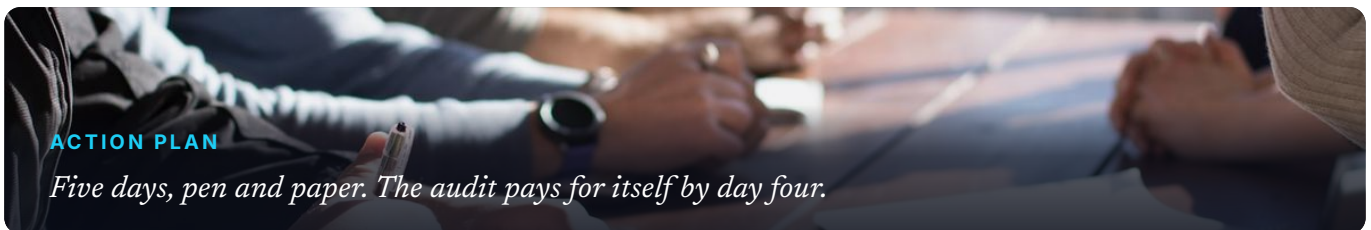
✗ The decision to drop a client

The system qualifies and scores. The final decision to discard (stop chasing, archive, say you are not a fit) is a human's. Discarding badly is expensive and does not show up in metrics until it is too late.

✗ Brand voice at critical moments

A welcome sequence with three typos, or the classic "{{name}}" not found", kills more trust than it builds. Before the system goes live, a person reviews — word by word — the 5-10 messages a new customer will see. After that, you can loosen up.

If you read this section and think "this is common sense" — correct. But 80% of failed automation projects in SMBs fail exactly here.



ACTION

What to do tomorrow

Assuming you have identified your priority leak, a five-day plan.



DAY 1 · 1 HOUR

Measure

Get the real number, not the feeling. If your leak is lead response, export the last 30 leads and compute the median. If it is proposals, list the last 30 with their current status. If it is content, count the channels each piece lived on.

DAY 2 · 2 HOURS

Decide

Take your priority leak and answer, in writing, the 2-3 "decision it calls for" questions from its chapter. Do not move forward without these answers. Any tool bought without them is money thrown away.

DAY 3 · 2-3 HOURS

Design the flow on paper

Literally pen and paper. What triggers what, on which channel, with which message, with which exit conditions. If it does not fit on one sheet, it is over-engineered.

DAY 4 · HALF A DAY

Move the flow into a system

If it is simple (a follow-up email cadence), your CRM can do it. If it is complex (several tools talking to each other), weigh up building in-house, outsourcing, or using a platform like n8n or Make.

DAY 5 · 1 HOUR

Define how you will measure success

A concrete metric, a cadence, a success threshold. Skip this and in 3 months you will not know whether you fixed anything.

At 30 days, check the number. **At 90 days**, decide whether to scale to the next leak.



NEXT STEP

Found your priority leak?

A 30-minute diagnosis. No strings attached. You leave with three priorities and, if we are a fit, a proposal within a week.

[Book a 30-minute diagnosis →](#)

moslabs.zohobookings.eu/#/moslabs



Jose María Moscardó

8+ years in B2B marketing (CHEP, Nielsen, OpenUp). I founded MosLab to fix exactly this kind of leak in small and mid-sized businesses, with intelligent automation and process consulting.